Becoming Like God

The Belief Files

Case File 004

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | LDS origins and authority | November 2026

Investigation summary

Joseph Smith taught that human beings could receive divine glory. During the final years of his life, he also taught about God's own history and the eternal existence of intelligence. Latter-day Saints understand these teachings as restored truth about humanity's relationship with Heavenly Father. This case investigates the surviving record, the proposed connection with ancient Christianity, and the biblical passages used to support the claim. [1–7]

The documents establish that exaltation was a developing and substantial part of early LDS teaching. They do not independently verify the divine history Smith described. Ancient Christian writers also taught participation in divine life, so the comparison requires more care than saying that Christians never spoke of becoming divine. The question is whether the same words carry the same account of God, creation, and salvation. [3–7, 15–19]

For a Christian reader, the central issue is the relationship between God's eternal identity and the transformation of people who depend on him. This investigation separates the evidence that a teaching was delivered from the theological judgment that it was revealed by God. Neither a sermon transcript nor the observation that a doctrine developed can, by itself, establish the speaker's private intent.

The claim under investigation

The claim has several parts that should be examined separately:

- Human beings have a divine relationship and potential that extend beyond ordinary moral improvement. [2, 6]
- Through Jesus Christ, faithful people can receive exaltation, including promises expressed in LDS scripture as becoming gods. [3, 5–6]
- Intelligence and the elements are eternal rather than created from nothing. The meaning of intelligence within later LDS thought requires further definition. [4, 6]
- Smith taught that the Father had experienced a life comparable in some respects to human life. The extent and present doctrinal weight of further deductions about that history must be distinguished from this historical finding. [7–13]
- These teachings restore truths present in the Bible and ancient Christianity. This is a claim about continuity as well as authority; a shared phrase alone cannot establish it. [2, 15–22]

The project writes from an evangelical and Trinitarian Christian perspective. Catholic and Orthodox accounts of participation in divine life are included because an accurate Christian comparison cannot reduce their teaching to a purely figurative change of behavior. Their agreement with LDS terminology at some points does not settle their agreement with LDS theology. [18–19]

How this investigation weighs evidence

A dated document can establish what a community taught. It does not automatically establish that the events or realities described in that document occurred. The early revelations and sermon reports are evidence for the history of LDS belief; their status as revelation is the claim being evaluated.

Different sources carry different weight. A contemporary revelation manuscript, an abbreviated sermon report, a later recollection, a canonized text, and a modern explanatory essay answer different questions. Agreement among sermon reporters strengthens an attribution to Smith. It does not turn those reporters into eyewitnesses of the Father's alleged earlier life.

Ancient parallels require context. To compare deification, sometimes called theosis, ask who God is before the transformation, who human beings are, what grace accomplishes, and whether creation remains dependent on its Creator. Similar language can express substantially different answers.

Conclusions are limited to the sources reviewed. This case is not a complete history of every Christian or LDS theory of deification. It tests the main historical bridge proposed in the supplied research packet against a small, identified set of primary texts. [1]

The historical timeline

Date	Documentary development	Investigative significance
1832	The vision now in Doctrine and Covenants 76 describes the exalted as gods and sons of God. [3, 6]	Divine status language predates the final Nauvoo sermons.
1833	The revelation now in section 93 discusses divine fullness, uncreated intelligence, and eternal elements. [4, 6]	It adds claims about human origins and reality itself.
1840 as later recalled	Lorenzo Snow associated his couplet about God's past and human destiny with this year. [13]	The dating comes through retrospective testimony, not an identified 1840 autograph in this review.
July 1843	The revelation now in section 132 connects eternal marriage with exaltation and becoming gods. [5–6]	Exaltation is joined to covenants and continuing family relationships.
April 1844	Smith delivers the King Follett discourse at a funeral setting in Nauvoo. Several reports survive. [7–10]	The reports permit comparison of his late teaching, with limits on exact wording.
June 1844	A further discourse reported by Thomas Bullock addresses the plurality of gods. [12]	Related teaching appears beyond a single funeral sermon.
August 1844	A printed version of the April discourse appears after Smith's death. [11]	Publication and later quotation must be distinguished from the original delivery.

Exhibit one The early revelations

The 1832 vision, associated with Smith and Sidney Rigdon, places its promises within a Christian vocabulary of Jesus, resurrection, glory, and the Father's kingdom. Its exalted recipients are described as gods and sons of God, while belonging to Christ. This is substantial evidence that strong divine status language belonged to early LDS revelation. It should not be dismissed as a late critic's invention. [3, 6]

The 1833 revelation adds a different kind of claim. Doctrine and Covenants 93:29 says that intelligence, or the light of truth, was not created or made; verse 33 describes the elements as eternal. These propositions concern what ultimately exists. They cannot be reduced to a promise that believers will become kinder or receive resurrection bodies. However, this text alone does not answer every later question about the relationship between intelligence, individual identity, and spirit birth. [4, 6]

The July 1843 revelation connects exaltation with a marriage covenant understood to endure beyond death. Section 132:19-20 associates that promise with continuing posterity, dominion, and becoming gods. The surviving historical manuscript is a contemporary copy; identifying its transmission is more precise than describing it as an extant original in Smith's own hand. [5–6]

These documents establish a sequence of recorded teachings. Calling that sequence progressive revelation is an LDS interpretation of its cause. Calling it religious development describes the observable sequence but still leaves its cause open. The historical record and the competing explanation should remain visible to the reader.

Exhibit two The King Follett discourse

On April 7, 1844, Smith preached in connection with the death of King Follett. The Joseph Smith Papers identifies six surviving individual accounts. This case concentrates on the reports associated with Thomas Bullock, William Clayton, Willard Richards, and Wilford Woodruff. The existence of other accounts should not be erased by turning this selected comparison into a claim that only four survive. [7–10]

The records differ in length and form. Bullock's report is comparatively extensive but abbreviated. Clayton's ends abruptly. Richards's is brief and compressed. Woodruff's journal preserves an additional account, which must be considered with its recording history rather than automatically treated as a word-for-word transcript taken continuously during the sermon. These limitations affect the confidence attached to a particular polished quotation. [7–10]

Bullock's report includes Smith's comparison between the Father's prior experience and the earthly life of Jesus. It also presents human divine potential as something to be learned and attained. The broad substance of Smith's late teaching is more secure than every word of a later combined version. A reader should distinguish a reporter's wording from the exact wording of the speaker. [7]

The sermon later appeared in the Times and Seasons. Since that publication followed Smith's death, its printed wording is evidence of transmission and reception as well as a report of the discourse. It should not be represented as an audio recording or a final text personally checked by Smith. Compare the individual accounts before building an argument on one sentence. [11]

The June 16 discourse provides a further test. Bullock again reported Smith speaking about plurality in the divine realm. This makes it difficult to explain the April material entirely as an isolated accident of one reporter. It still does not supply independent access to the divine realities Smith claimed to describe. [12]

Exhibit three The ancient Christian comparison

The claim that early Christians never spoke of becoming divine is historically unsustainable. In On the Incarnation, section 54, Athanasius writes: "He was made man that we might be made God." A fair investigation must allow that language to stand before asking what it means. [15]

The same work also affirms God's creation of the universe from nothing through the Word. Its deification language therefore does not require the LDS proposition that intelligence and the elements are uncreated. Athanasius connects humanity's restoration with the action of the divine Word; his account must be read as a whole. Elsewhere, his defense of the eternal Trinity also resists treating God's identity as something acquired over time. [15–16]

Theophilus provides another useful control. In To Autolycus, book II, chapter 4, he rejects the view that matter is as uncreated as God and argues for God's ability to create from nothing. His argument is directed against a position he attributes to Plato. That passage prevents a simple assertion that creation from nothing was merely adopted from Greek belief in eternal matter. It does not, by itself, settle the entire history of Christian creation doctrine. [17]

These examples do not prove that every early Christian agreed about every detail of salvation or creation. They show why a quotation about becoming divine cannot be detached from its author's account of the Creator. The historical task is to compare whole claims, not collect striking phrases.

Present Christian traditions also matter. The Catholic Catechism uses participation in divine nature to explain the purpose of the Incarnation. Orthodox teaching describes real communion with God and growth by grace. These are current Christian uses of divine participation language. They make a sweeping claim that such language disappeared from Christianity difficult to sustain. [18–19]

The narrower LDS restoration argument remains a separate proposition: that Smith restored the correct understanding of these ideas, even where others

retained some vocabulary. Establishing that proposition requires more than demonstrating that ancient authors used the word God in connection with transformed human beings.

Assessing the principal accounts

Witness group	What the evidence can establish	What it cannot independently establish
Revelation manuscripts and copies	Early LDS texts contain exaltation teachings and claims about eternal reality. [3–5]	That the texts originated with God.
April sermon reporters	Smith taught substantial ideas about divine potential and the Father's history. Exact wording varies. [7–10]	That reporters had observed the Father's history themselves.
Later printed sermon	Followers published and transmitted the teaching after Smith's death. [11]	That every printed sentence is an exact, personally approved transcript.
Lorenzo Snow recollections	Snow and later LDS teaching associated his couplet with an earlier revelatory experience. [13]	That the surviving modern account is an 1840 diary or independent verification of God's past.
Ancient Christian authors	Divine participation language existed in identifiable Christian texts. [15–17]	That those authors taught Smith's entire account of God and human origins.

The reliability question changes with the claim. A report may be strong evidence that a sermon was delivered and weak evidence that its supernatural assertions are true. That distinction applies to LDS and Christian sources alike; the Christian theological assessment later in this case must also give reasons for its reading of Scripture.

Snow's couplet is often quoted as a summary: "As man now is, God once was: As God now is, man may be." The modern LDS manual traces its

account through later recollections and publications, including an 1884 biography. That provenance matters when comparing Snow's chronology with Smith's public teaching. [13]

There are also limits to what should be attributed to current LDS doctrine. A historical sermon, a canonical section, and a modern explanation do not have identical status. Arguments about God's alleged prior sins, endless family trees of gods, or an assigned private planet must not be presented as settled conclusions of this case. The evidence reviewed does not warrant those additions. [2, 6–13]

The strongest LDS argument

The strongest defense begins with the breadth of biblical promises: divine participation in 2 Peter, adoption and shared inheritance in Romans, and the transformation of believers into Christ's likeness. It then places Smith's revelations alongside ancient Christian deification language. On this reading, LDS teaching restores the full promise of salvation rather than inventing an aspiration forbidden by Christianity. [2, 15, 20–22]

An LDS reader can also argue that continuing revelation is expected to clarify matters left less explicit in earlier texts. Development across Smith's ministry would then fit the model rather than disprove it. The covenants and ordinances associated with exaltation would be understood as responses to Christ's saving work, not human achievements that make his Atonement unnecessary. Current LDS teaching explicitly presents grace as a divine gift. [6, 14]

That argument deserves an answer at its strongest point. The presence of real biblical transformation and ancient deification language is a genuine historical connection. The unresolved step is whether those sources establish the distinctive additional claims: uncreated intelligence, the Father's earlier experience, and the specific covenant structure described in LDS revelation. Similarity provides a comparison to investigate; it does not supply the missing demonstration.

Competing explanations

Restoration through continuing revelation

Smith received additional truth about God's nature and humanity's destiny. The early revelations, Nauvoo sermons, and biblical promises form a progressively disclosed whole. This interpretation can accommodate development and incomplete early explanations. Its distinguishing claim is divine disclosure, which the existence of the documents alone cannot verify.

Religious development and scriptural expansion

Smith developed an increasingly expansive theology through interpretation, religious imagination, and the concerns of his community. The chronological record is compatible with this explanation as well. Compatibility does not establish exactly which influences caused a particular idea, and it does not prove that Smith consciously fabricated revelation.

Partial continuity with substantial differences

LDS exaltation and earlier Christian deification share themes of divine likeness, glory, and transformed life while differing about God's identity and the origin of humanity. This account explains why genuine parallels and serious theological disagreement can coexist. It requires defining each proposition rather than treating the entire subject as either wholly identical or wholly unrelated.

Deliberate religious invention

A critic may suggest that the doctrine was knowingly constructed to support authority or other aims. That possibility involves a claim about intent. Documentary development, extraordinary claims, or later institutional benefits do not independently demonstrate knowledge of falsity. Establishing deception would require additional evidence directed to that question.

The available record strongly supports the historical development of the teaching. It does not allow a neutral historical procedure to confirm every proposed supernatural cause or private motive. The biblical comparison tests a further question: whether a Christian should accept the resulting claims as consistent with the scriptural account of God.

Motives benefits and costs

The King Follett discourse was delivered in a setting of bereavement. Teaching about enduring identity, resurrection, and growth could offer hope to people facing death. A historian can identify that setting and the doctrine's possible appeal without assuming that pastoral usefulness proves either divine origin or manipulation. [7–10]

Exaltation also gives religious authority practical significance. If particular covenants are necessary for the highest promised destiny, the authority to administer those covenants matters profoundly. Section 132 makes that relationship a legitimate subject for investigation. It does not, without further evidence, show why Smith believed or taught it. [5–6]

Benefits, sacrifices, opposition, and sincere commitment can exist together within a movement. The reader should resist assigning a single motive to every teacher or believer. The appropriate question is what each source documents, whose perspective it represents, and how far an explanation extends beyond that evidence.

A biblical assessment

Participation in divine nature

Second Peter 1:3-11 connects divine promises with escape from corruption and growth in virtue, knowledge, self-control, patience, godliness, affection, and love. Verse 4 must be read within that movement of the argument. The text promises a profound transformation of life; it does not describe the Father's former mortality or teach that human intelligence is uncreated. [20]

The Christian assessment should not weaken this passage merely to avoid LDS vocabulary. Participation in divine life can be affirmed while asking whether its explanation preserves the difference between the eternal Creator and those he saves. Catholic and Orthodox traditions give fuller accounts of this participation than this short investigation can supply. [18–20]

Gods in Psalm 82 and John 10

Jesus cites Psalm 82 in John 10:34-36 during a dispute about his identity and the charge of blasphemy. The referents in Psalm 82 are debated, including readings involving human authorities and readings involving heavenly beings. A comparison should not present one of those readings as the only interpretation ever seriously proposed. [21]

The immediate argument in John concerns the legitimacy of Jesus' claim about his relationship with the Father. Whatever position a reader takes on Psalm 82's referents, a further argument is needed to derive from these passages a complete history of God's progression or a particular system of eternal marriage. The occurrence of the word gods does not establish every later use of that word.

Adoption glory and the Creator

Romans 8:14-30 presents believers as adopted children, heirs with Christ, and people destined to be conformed to the Son's image. These promises should be stated with their full force. Adoption into God's family and future glorification are central Christian hopes, not embarrassing exceptions to be explained away. [22]

The same biblical comparison must consider Isaiah 43:10 and 44:6, John 1:1-3, and Colossians 1:16-17. These passages ground the Christian understanding of God's uniqueness and the dependence of creation on the divine Word. From this project's Trinitarian perspective, people receive life and glory from the Creator; they do not become additional uncreated beings alongside him. This is a theological reading of the passages considered together. [22]

Genesis uses language about creation, and Smith's sermons discuss Hebrew terms. A single word study of create or gods cannot settle the whole issue. Arguments about creation from nothing require a broader account of the biblical text and its reception. Readers should not treat an English sermon report as sufficient evidence for a disputed Hebrew linguistic conclusion. [7, 11, 17]

God's faithfulness and the Incarnation

Numbers 23:19 contrasts God's faithfulness with human lying and changing of mind in the Balaam narrative. It should not be quoted as if it simply meant that God could never take human nature. Christians affirm the Incarnation of the Son. The relevant distinction is between that confession and the claim that the Father had an earlier history through which he became God. [22]

This distinction permits a direct disagreement about Smith's teaching without making an argument that would also undermine the Christian account of Jesus. It also reminds the reader to investigate the meaning of a biblical sentence in its setting before turning it into a slogan.

Grace obedience and eternal marriage

Ephesians 2:8-10 and Titus 3:4-7 ground salvation in God's mercy and grace, with good works following the new life he gives. James 2 addresses the emptiness of a professed faith that produces no action. The project's evangelical reading distinguishes the basis of salvation from its fruit; it does not teach that obedience is irrelevant. [22]

A fair LDS comparison must likewise acknowledge that current LDS teaching makes Christ and grace indispensable. The disagreement concerns how exaltation, covenants, authority, and obedience relate to the saving gift, rather than whether LDS people ever speak about grace. Ask what saved and exalted mean in the particular conversation before assuming agreement or disagreement. [6, 14]

Matthew 22:23-33 discusses marriage in the resurrection in response to a question about a woman who had several successive husbands. Its

immediate setting matters. LDS interpreters distinguish marriages made after resurrection from sealings established beforehand; Christian critics question whether that distinction is supported by Jesus' answer. State both the passage and the proposed response before evaluating section 132. The detailed history of temple and marriage teaching belongs in later cases. [5–6, 22]

Findings and confidence

Confidence here concerns the stated documentary finding, not a numerical probability assigned to a spiritual claim.

Finding	Confidence	Basis and limit
Early LDS texts teach exaltation.	High	Dated revelations and current canonical texts. [3–6]
Smith taught about the Father's prior experience.	High for the broad attribution	Multiple sermon records; exact wording requires comparison. [7–12]
Ancient Christians used deification language.	High	Identifiable texts, including Athanasius. [15–17]
Those parallels establish identical theology.	Not established	Creation and God's eternal identity differ in the texts reviewed.
The records verify God's alleged prior history.	Not established	Reporters transmit a teaching rather than independent observation.
The doctrine's development proves deliberate fraud.	Not established	Development does not independently establish knowledge of falsity.

Overall assessment

The historical record supports a substantial conclusion: exaltation and related teachings about eternal reality developed within Smith's ministry and were not simply invented by later opponents. The late sermon evidence should be read with its textual limitations, but those limitations do not erase the broad teaching. [3–12]

The proposed ancient connection contains a real point of contact. Christian deification language exists. It does not establish the full LDS account of divine and human origins, and the ancient texts examined here include commitments that differ from that account. A responsible comparison should preserve both the connection and the difference. [15–19]

From this project's Christian perspective, the biblical promise is that God saves, adopts, transforms, and glorifies people through Christ. The claim that the Father became God through an earlier history, or that human intelligence is uncreated, requires support beyond the biblical promises reviewed here. Readers should recognize that this final conclusion is a theological assessment informed by the evidence, not an experimentally demonstrated account of heaven.

Read compare and discuss

Read Doctrine and Covenants 76:50-70, 93:19-35, and 132:19-24 alongside 2 Peter 1:3-11, Romans 8:14-30, and John 1:1-18. Then compare a King Follett report with Athanasius, On the Incarnation, sections 3 and 54. Keep a separate list of shared words and distinct propositions. [6–7, 15, 20, 22]

1. Which source establishes that Smith taught an idea, and which source is offered to establish that the idea is true?
2. What does becoming like God mean in each text: transformed character, shared life, divine glory, eternal family, uncreated identity, or something else?
3. Does a promise of participation require that the participant and God have the same origin? What argument would establish that additional step?

4. How does Athanasius's teaching about creation affect the meaning of his deification language?
5. What is lost when either side describes the other only through a hostile summary?
6. Which points are explicit in a canonical passage, and which depend on later explanation?
7. Where does your own conclusion depend on a theological commitment rather than a direct historical observation?

For a conversation with an LDS friend, begin with a question: "When you say we can become like Heavenly Father, what do you understand that to include?" Listen before selecting a passage. A useful follow-up is: "How do you distinguish sharing God's life and glory from the question of whether God has always been God?" Explain your Christian conviction in ordinary language and allow the person to describe their own understanding.

For group or family study, have one person summarize the strongest LDS interpretation and another summarize the Christian assessment. Each should check with the other that the summary is fair before discussing the disagreement. The aim is a clearer understanding of the claim and an honest explanation of the gospel, without turning a friend into a debate exercise.

Accuracy notes and further research

- The supplied research packet is a working synthesis, not independent primary corroboration. Assertions from it have been narrowed where the reviewed evidence does not justify a broader conclusion. [1]
- The April discourse survives through reports with different recording histories. This case selects four accounts from a larger surviving set; it does not claim four perfect or wholly independent transcripts. [7–10]
- Snow's 1840 dating is presented through later recollection. A modern manual's quotation of a recollection does not make it a contemporary 1840 record. [13]
- Historical attribution does not give every sermon sentence the same doctrinal status as a canonical text. Current explanations should be distinguished from historical speculation. [2, 6–13]
- Deification in early Christianity is a substantial topic with internal diversity. This case uses a limited comparison; it does not claim to survey every author, date the first appearance of creation from nothing, or resolve all Orthodox and Catholic distinctions. [15–19]
- Biblical interpretations are identified as interpretations. Psalm 82's referents, the relationship of John 10 to it, and the implications of Matthew 22 require more discussion than a single quotation permits. [21–22]
- Further work for a book should include fuller comparison of all six April sermon accounts, a specialist review of ancient deification and creation texts, and consistent treatment of the doctrinal authority of each LDS source.
- Mother in Heaven, priesthood and temples, and the historical practice of plural marriage receive their own cases. Their inclusion in the series should not be mistaken for completed research or publication of those cases.

Sources and reading

The register distinguishes the supplied research, early documents, current religious teaching, and biblical texts. Numbered notes identify the sources relevant to a claim; citing a source does not endorse every conclusion in it. Web sources checked November 8, 2026. Biblical discussion uses the KJV text, distinguished from a publisher's headings and interpretive notes.

[1] Supplied project research. *LDS Gospel Topics Essays*, compiled 366-page PDF, Becoming Like God source packet, physical PDF pages 292-323. Provided research and working interpretations; not an independent witness to the historical events. The publication index separately tracks research packets and finished case files.

[2] Current LDS explanation. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Becoming Like God. Consult the full essay and notes for the Church's framing, qualifications, and proposed ancient parallels. Its explanation is a source for current LDS presentation, not independent confirmation of the ancient claim.

[3] Early LDS revelation. Joseph Smith Papers, Vision 16 February 1832, especially the page containing gods and sons of God. Preserved through a manuscript copy in Revelation Book 2; compare the historical transcription with current section 76.

[4] Early LDS revelation. Joseph Smith Papers, Revelation 6 May 1833. Historical manuscript and editorial description for the revelation now in section 93. It supplies a dated textual witness, not external verification of uncreated intelligence.

[5] Nauvoo revelation. Joseph Smith Papers, Revelation 12 July 1843. Surviving contemporary copy associated with Joseph Kingsbury. Distinguish the copy from the original dictation record and from later recollections about that record.

[6] Current LDS canonical texts. Doctrine and Covenants 76:50-70, 93:19-35, and 132:19-24. Principal passages for glory, intelligence, eternal elements, covenant marriage, and exaltation. Compare the text itself rather than treating headings as additional revelation.

[7] Contemporary sermon report. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 7 April 1844 as reported by Thomas Bullock, including page 3. Historical introduction identifies the larger body of surviving accounts. Abbreviated reporting and editorial comparison matter when quoting exact words.

[8] Sermon account in a journal. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 7 April 1844 as reported by Wilford Woodruff. Read with its source note and recording history; the

surviving journal account should not automatically be equated with a complete stenographic record.

[9] Contemporary sermon report. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 7 April 1844 as reported by William Clayton. An additional record with an abrupt ending, identified and compared in the Papers' historical introduction. Its existence supports comparison without eliminating textual differences.

[10] Contemporary sermon report. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 7 April 1844 as reported by Willard Richards. Brief and compressed reporting, discussed alongside the fuller accounts. Do not turn its brevity into a claim that every subject absent from it was absent from the sermon.

[11] Posthumous published sermon. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 7 April 1844 as published in Times and Seasons, August 15, 1844, pages 612-617. Publication followed Smith's death. Read the printed presentation alongside the individual reports rather than substituting it silently for them.

[12] Additional late discourse. Joseph Smith Papers, Discourse 16 June 1844 as reported by Thomas Bullock. Evidence for further teaching about plurality of gods; distinguish the report from later accounts and from independent proof of the teaching's truth.

[13] Retrospective Snow tradition. *Teachings of Presidents of the Church Lorenzo Snow*, Chapter 5 The Grand Destiny of the Faithful. The modern manual relates the 1840 experience through later testimony and cites, among other works, Eliza R. Snow Smith's 1884 biography. The biography is identified here through that citation, not claimed as separately inspected.

[14] Current LDS teaching on grace. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Grace Study Guide. Used to avoid equating LDS exaltation with a claim that salvation can be achieved without Christ or that grace is an earned payment. Interpretive differences about ordinances and obedience remain.

[15] Ancient Christian text in English translation. Athanasius, On the Incarnation, sections 3 and 54. The same work discusses creation from nothing and deification through the Word. This investigation consults an English translation, not a new analysis of the Greek manuscript tradition.

[16] Ancient Christian text in English translation. Athanasius, Against the Arians Discourse I, especially the discussion of the eternal Trinity in sections 17-18. Context

for his account of God; not an assertion that every later Christian formulation is already fully expressed in this passage.

[17] Ancient Christian text in English translation. Theophilus of Antioch, To Autolycus Book II, chapter 4. Contrasts God's creative power with the view that matter is uncreated. Consult the argument in context rather than using it to claim a complete chronology of Christian creation doctrine.

[18] Current Catholic teaching. Vatican, Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraph 460. A current authoritative presentation of participation in divine nature through the Incarnation, with references to earlier Christian writers. It is not itself an ancient manuscript.

[19] Current Orthodox teaching. Orthodox Church in America, The Orthodox Faith God. Presents communion with God and likeness by grace. Used as a current Orthodox explanation rather than a survey of all historical Orthodox accounts of theosis.

[20] Biblical text. 2 Peter 1, especially verses 3-11. Read the divine nature promise with its surrounding account of corruption, virtue, and knowledge. The assessment distinguishes the text from later explanations of its implications.

[21] Biblical texts. John 10, especially verses 30-39, and its quotation of Psalm 82:6. Compare the whole psalm and the immediate dispute in John. This case acknowledges disputed identifications of the psalm's gods rather than presenting a single interpretation as an uncontested fact.

[22] Biblical comparison passages. KJV: Genesis 1; Numbers 23:19; Isaiah 43:10 and 44:6; Matthew 22:23-33; John 1:1-18; Romans 8:14-30; Ephesians 2:8-10; Colossians 1:16-17; Titus 3:4-7; James 2:14-26. These passages supply the stated Christian comparison. Conclusions about their combined implications are theological judgments, not additional historical documents about Smith.

Collection notes

This is Case File 004 in The Belief Files LDS collection. Read 00 LDS and biblical Christianity first, then Cases 001-012 in order or by topic. The Christian conversation guide closes the collection separately. Later numbered cases remain planned until individually researched, prepared, checked, and published.